

The Morning Briefing

US Politics & the Judiciary — Israel & the Middle East — Rome & the Vatican — the World — Research & Long Reads

LEAD STORY — ISRAEL / MIDDLE EAST

US and Israel Reportedly Prepare Weekend Strikes on Iran's Power Grid; Embassies Tell Americans to Be Ready to Leave

Officials brief a campaign against energy infrastructure as Tehran warns of a "decisive response" — treat the leaks as pressure, not policy.

US POLITICS

Senate Confirms Jay Clayton as Director of National Intelligence, 51-47

The Senate confirmed Walter "Jay" Clayton as Director of National Intelligence on a straight party-line vote, replacing Bill Pulte, the housing official Trump had installed temporarily with no intelligence background. Clayton chaired the SEC during Trump's first term and later returned to his old law firm, Sullivan & Cromwell. During his confirmation hearing, Democrats pressed him on his reluctance to directly affirm that Trump lost the 2020 election, and raised concern he could cave to pressure to politicize intelligence. The confirmation could unlock movement on a surveillance authority that has been lapsed for more than six weeks.

WHY IT MATTERS

This seat sits at the center of the intelligence-politicization fight documented in today's Research & Long Reads section — the DNI is the office whose occupant decides whether dissenting analysts keep their clearances.

NPR — [npr.org/2026/07/29/nx-s1-5910749/senate-confirms-jay-clayton-as-director-of-national-intelligence](https://www.npr.org/2026/07/29/nx-s1-5910749/senate-confirms-jay-clayton-as-director-of-national-intelligence)

Senate Unanimously Rejects Any Pardon for Ghislaine Maxwell

The Senate passed S.Res.608 by unanimous consent, declaring that Ghislaine Maxwell should receive no presidential pardon or clemency for her crimes with Jeffrey

Epstein. Sen. Jacky Rosen (D-NV) forced the vote; no Republican objected, putting every Senate Republican on record against Trump, who has refused to rule a pardon out. The resolution is non-binding. Maxwell is serving a 20-year sentence for conspiring with Epstein to sexually abuse minors.

Axios — [axios.com/2026/07/29/ghislaine-maxwell-jeffrey-epstein-senate-pardon](https://www.axios.com/2026/07/29/ghislaine-maxwell-jeffrey-epstein-senate-pardon)

House Heads Home; Senate Builds Its Own Spending Package

The House recessed July 30 and will not return until August 31, after passing H.R. 9770, the Continuing Appropriations Act 2027, by a vote of 220-205. The Senate will not take up that House-passed bill; it is instead assembling its own package built around anomalies negotiated directly with the White House. Speaker Mike Johnson is campaigning across 17 states and roughly 30 districts, while Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries has launched Democrats' "100 days of action" to mark 100 days until the midterms.

Federal News Network — [federalnewsnetwork.com/congress/2026/07/as-congress-sprints-to-august-recess-major-decisions-await](https://www.federalnewsnetwork.com/congress/2026/07/as-congress-sprints-to-august-recess-major-decisions-await)

JUDICIARY

9th Circuit, 2-1, Restores Bond Hearings for Detained Immigrants

A divided panel of the 9th U.S. Circuit Court of Appeals ruled July 30 that the administration cannot categorically deny detained immigrants a chance at bond hearings, rejecting the government's expanded mandatory-detention policy. The majority included a judge appointed by President Trump.

ACLU — [aclu.org/press-releases/two-more-federal-appeals-courts-reject-trump-policy-that-seeks-to-deny-access-to-bond-hearings](https://www.aclu.org/press-releases/two-more-federal-appeals-courts-reject-trump-policy-that-seeks-to-deny-access-to-bond-hearings)

Judge Again Blocks End of TPS for Somalis

A federal judge issued a new administrative stay on July 31 blocking the administration from ending Temporary Protected Status for Somali nationals, after plaintiffs filed an amended complaint and emergency motion. It is the second time a court has intervened on the same policy.

Coverage aggregator — [twitchy.com/brettt/2026/08/01/federal-judge-again-blocks-trump-administration-from-ending-tps-for-somalis-n2430848](https://www.twitch.com/brettt/2026/08/01/federal-judge-again-blocks-trump-administration-from-ending-tps-for-somalis-n2430848)

1st Circuit Upholds Block on Federal Voter List, Denies H-1B Stay

The 1st U.S. Circuit Court of Appeals upheld an injunction blocking Trump's order to build a federal citizen-voter list and restrict mail-ballot delivery to people on it; twenty-three states and the District of Columbia sued, arguing the Constitution gives states and Congress, not the president, authority over election rules. Separately, the same circuit denied the administration's request to stay a lower-court

ruling that struck down Trump's \$100,000 H-1B visa proclamation, finding the government had not shown a likelihood of success on the merits.

WHY IT MATTERS

Circuit courts, including judges Trump himself appointed, keep checking the administration's immigration and election orders ahead of the midterms — a pattern worth reading alongside the DNI and intelligence-politicization stories.

CBS News — [cbsnews.com/news/appeals-court-upholds-ruling-blocking-trump-order-federal-voter-list](https://www.cbsnews.com/news/appeals-court-upholds-ruling-blocking-trump-order-federal-voter-list)

ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST

US and Israel Said to Prepare Strikes on Iran's Energy Grid

The United States and Israel are reportedly preparing one of the harshest bombing campaigns to date against Iran's energy infrastructure — power plants and refineries, with some discussion of cutting electricity to Tehran entirely — with strikes possible over the weekend. American embassies across the region warned citizens Saturday to prepare for sudden escalation and consider leaving; the embassy in Amman separately warned Americans away from US military bases in Jordan that have already taken Iranian missile fire, and the alert for Israel urged citizens to identify their nearest bomb shelter. Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi warned that any US or Israeli "aggression" would be met with a "decisive response."

ANALYTICAL READ

This is being reported through anonymous Israeli and US officials briefing friendly outlets, not a joint public policy statement — treat it as positioning and pressure, not settled fact. Striking a national power grid goes well past the "self-defense" framing usually attached to Israeli operations, and it is the United States, not Israel, that would absorb the costs of a wider war: oil markets, American forces already based across Iraq, Syria, and Jordan, and the very embassies now telling citizens to leave. Israel's incentive to keep an Iran confrontation open-ended is not identical to Washington's — Netanyahu's coalition has drawn political cover from a wartime footing for well over a year.

HNGN — hngn.com/articles/272523/20260801/us-israel-prepare-weekend-strikes-iran-energy-sites-embassies-warn-escalation.htm

Knesset Shields Haredi Draft Evaders Through Early 2027

The Knesset passed a law 58-54 banning the arrest and prosecution of ultra-Orthodox men evading military service, legitimizing continued mass Haredi non-enlistment through late January 2027. Netanyahu has

since said the arrest-freeze law "failed" and now backs a broader conscription bill that he says meets IDF needs — while indicating full-time yeshiva students will still get a pass.

ANALYTICAL READ

This is a coalition-survival maneuver, not a security policy — it directly overrides a unanimous 2024 High Court ruling that required the government to draft yeshiva students absent a legal exemption framework. It is a domestic rule-of-law story dressed up as a defense bill, and worth watching for whether Washington holds an ally to the same standard it would apply to a rival state overriding its own courts.

Times of Israel — [timesofisrael.com/knesset-passes-law-banning-arrests-of-haredi-draft-dodgers-legitimizing-ongoing-non-enlistment](https://www.timesofisrael.com/knesset-passes-law-banning-arrests-of-haredi-draft-dodgers-legitimizing-ongoing-non-enlistment)

IDF Said to Rule Out Gaza Withdrawal Before "Full Disarmament"

A diplomatic source told the Jerusalem Post the IDF will not withdraw from its current Yellow Line position in Gaza prior to Hamas's full disarmament, even as a senior minister said Israel is not halting strikes in the territory and cast doubt on whether Hamas will actually disarm.

ANALYTICAL READ

"Full disarmament" is an open-ended bar that Israel itself controls the definition of, and this is sourced to a single anonymous diplomatic contact rather than a public IDF position — functionally a rationale for indefinite presence rather than a withdrawal plan.

Times of Israel — [timesofisrael.com/liveblog-august-2-2026](https://www.timesofisrael.com/liveblog-august-2-2026)

Quiet Diplomacy on Lebanon, Syria, Bahrain

Alongside the Iran buildup, there is quieter diplomatic movement on three fronts: Israel-Lebanon negotiations, a possible Syrian security arrangement, and renewed Bahrain-Israel engagement. Analysts disagree over how durable any of these openings actually are.

ITALY, ROME & THE VATICAN

Pope Leo XIV Appeals for Ceuta as Migration Crisis Deepens

Following the Sunday Angelus in St. Peter's Square, Pope Leo XIV made an appeal in Spanish over the migration emergency in Ceuta, the Spanish autonomous city on the

North African coast bordering Morocco: *"I follow with concern the alarming situation in Ceuta, asking God, through the intercession of Our Lady of Africa, that solutions of peace, stability, and justice may be found."* Tens of thousands of people have attempted to cross from

Morocco into Ceuta in recent days, overwhelming reception facilities and prompting Spain to deploy additional security forces. At least 67 people have died in the crossings, most drowned at sea or crushed in the chaos, according to Reuters. The Diocese of Cadiz and Ceuta pledged cooperation with public authorities on July 31.

The Pope also prayed for an end to wars worldwide, remembering "the weakest and most defenseless" caught in conflict — children, the elderly, and the sick — and asked the Lord to "comfort those who suffer and bless the work of all those who bring help and consolation."

The Pardon of Assisi

The Pope recalled the Pardon of Assisi, the plenary indulgence tied to a vision St. Francis of Assisi received in 1216 at the Porziuncula, the small chapel he built in Assisi. According to the tradition, Christ asked Francis what he desired for the salvation of souls, and Francis asked for a plenary indulgence for all who entered the chapel; the grant was later extended to anyone visiting a parish or Franciscan church on August 1 or 2. It may be obtained through the sacraments of Reconciliation and the Eucharist, and by reciting the Creed and the Lord's Prayer while praying for the Pope's intentions.

Vatican News — vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-leo-xiv-impassioned-appeal-sunday-angelus-2-august-2026.html

WORLD

Ceuta Becomes a Spain-Morocco-EU Flashpoint

The migration emergency in Ceuta, now serious enough to draw a direct papal appeal, is testing whether Brussels treats a mass border crossing as a security problem to be sealed or a humanitarian one to be managed — a question with echoes across the EU's other frontier states.

Israel's Two Tracks: Deal-Making and Escalation

Israel's parallel diplomatic openings with Lebanon, Syria, and Bahrain sit awkwardly next to preparations for strikes on Iran's power grid. Regional capitals, and Washington's own regional posture, will say a good deal about which track actually wins out this week.

RESEARCH & LONG READS

What They Want to Hear: The Politicization of U.S. Intelligence

Julia Curlee — a former CIA analyst, President's Daily Brief briefer to the vice president, and NSC director in both the Biden and second Trump administrations — lays out a typology of how the intelligence community has been pressured since 2025: direct manipulation of conclusions, indirect politicization through taskings and access, cherry-picking of raw reporting, and retaliation against analysts through firings and clearance revocations. She traces the ouster of the National Intelligence Council chair over a Tren de Aragua assessment that undercut the administration's legal case for invoking the Alien Enemies Act, and argues the same failure pattern that produced the Iraq WMD fiasco is repeating around Iran. She proposes statutory fixes: enforceable tradecraft standards, an independent ombudsman, and accountable declassification.

TIES TO TODAY

Directly connects to the Jay Clayton DNI confirmation in US Politics above — the DNI is the office at the center of every episode Curlee documents.

Lawfare — lawfaremedia.org/article/what-they-want-to-hear--the-politicization-of-u.s.-intelligence

Apostolic Succession: The Unbroken Chain from Christ's Twelve

Garrett Ham (Yale Divinity) lays out a long-form defense of the Catholic doctrine that valid holy orders and sacraments require an unbroken chain of ordination traceable to the apostles. The piece traces the claim from Clement of Rome (c. AD 96) through Ignatius of Antioch and Irenaeus of Lyon (c. AD 180) to Tertullian's argument, around AD 200, that succession functions as a legal chain of title — the same logic the modern Catechism still relies on. It engages directly with the strongest Protestant counter-argument: that the New Testament uses "bishop" (episkopos) and "elder" (presbyteros) interchangeably, meaning the later threefold hierarchy of bishop-presbyter-deacon is a post-biblical development rather than an apostolic mandate.

Garrett Ham — garrettham.com/apostolic-succession